

Chapter 21_3 - Beauty

With a bang, the door closed, and Ning Fuyi shut her mouth with a dark expression.

Liu Wenzhu hurriedly pulled her back: "This place is really too strange. What should we do now? Should we really do as she said and have one person go next door?"

"Indeed strange." Ning Fuyi muttered as she turned around to survey their surroundings.

The private room's decor was not much different from ordinary mortal pleasure houses. Inside was a screen, behind which was a bed covered with brocade quilts. In front of the screen was a carved round table filled with fruits, small dishes, and a jar of wine.

Ning Fuyi went over to smell it - the wine was indeed wine, nothing wrong with it.

"Divine Venerable, what do you think?" Ning Fuyi intentionally tried to engage the silent Chu Qingqiu in conversation.

"Can't tell." Chu Qingqiu answered simply. Like Ning Fuyi, she was moving around the room and had walked behind the screen, reaching out to pull open a drawer beside the bed, seeming to want to discover something.

Ning Fuyi curiously went over to look. But as soon as the drawer was pulled open, Chu Qingqiu's expression changed dramatically. She slammed it shut and retreated three steps.

Her fair face visibly reddened to the roots. When Ning Fuyi reached out to open it for a look, a sharp pain shot through the back of her hand - the white jade flute had struck her hand hard, making Ning Fuyi quickly withdraw her hand and look at Chu Qingqiu with grievance.

"At such a young age, what are you looking at carelessly?" Chu Qingqiu scolded, then turned and left.

"Tch, old fogey¹." Ning Fuyi muttered with raised eyebrows. Taking advantage of Chu Qingqiu not paying attention, she turned back to pull open the drawer and look inside carefully.

"Whoa." She exclaimed in amazement.

After closing the drawer with disgust, Ning Fuyi walked out from behind the screen, only to see Chu Qingqiu and Liu Wenzhu standing together in front of a wall. Chu Qingqiu waved her sleeve across the wall surface, and the originally stone wall suddenly rippled like water, becoming crystal-like and revealing the scene in the opposite room clearly.

The woman from earlier was sitting on a beauty couch², holding a cup of wine in her fingers and pouring it into her mouth. Clear wine flowed down her chin, wetting her clothing.

The woman then reached out to untie her sash, and her outer garment slipped off - truly swaying and fragrant. Liu Wenzhu quickly covered her eyes, not daring to look anymore.

"How about we just grab her and beat her up, force her to tell us where that Man'er is?" Ning Fuyi crossed her arms and suddenly said.

"This building is full of mysteries. Do you want to alert them?" Chu Qingqiu spoke.

"Then there's no other way, unless we find someone to accompany her and extract information." Ning Fuyi leaned closer to look, her phoenix eyes carrying a smile. "This person is quite charming and attractive, rather good-looking."

"Ning Fuyi, don't forget you're a cultivator!" Chu Qingqiu said sternly.

Ning Fuyi closed her mouth, but the smile in her eyes didn't diminish. It wasn't that she really found that woman attractive, but being able to anger Chu Qingqiu had always been one of her pleasures.

"Does the Divine Venerable have any other good methods? Like casting a heart-stealing spell to confuse her mind?" Ning Fuyi said.

"This person is not simple. Ordinary immortal arts don't work on her." Chu Qingqiu paused. "I tried earlier."

She hadn't even noticed - Ning Fuyi sighed. Her cultivation was still insufficient.

"Then there's only the method I mentioned." Ning Fuyi tilted her head. "Guess which of us three handsome young men she would like?"

Chu Qingqiu's hands behind her back gripped the white jade flute tightly. For a moment she said nothing, but didn't object either.

"Wenzhu won't work. Just hearing those sounds makes her face red as a shrimp. If she really faced that woman, she'd only suffer." Ning Fuyi said lazily. "The Divine Venerable is the glory of the six realms, with a pure and noble body. How could she touch such a filthy place?"

"I'll go." As she spoke, she headed toward the door.

Sure enough, before her hand could touch the door handle, Chu Qingqiu's low shout came from behind: "Stop."

Ning Fuyi secretly smiled. She knew Chu Qingqiu wouldn't let a disciple do such things. That's why she deliberately provoked her - she had long wanted to see Chu Qingqiu in an awkward situation.

"Fine, I'll go." Chu Qingqiu said softly. She placed the white jade flute on the table and walked toward Ning Fuyi, her peach blossom eyes downcast. When she reached Ning Fuyi's side, she looked at her deeply.

"You two stay here. If anything goes wrong, you must call out for me." After Chu Qingqiu finished her instructions, she opened the door and left.

"Alright." Ning Fuyi felt no guilt and waved at her, then whispered: "That girl is eighteen years old³, named Man'er, with a flower-shaped birthmark on her forehead."

Chu Qingqiu hummed in acknowledgment.

Footnotes:

1. **Old fogey (老古董)** - A colloquial term meaning someone who is old-fashioned or conservative
 2. **Beauty couch (美人榻)** - An elegant reclining couch traditionally used by women, often found in pleasure houses
 3. **Eighteen years old (年方二八)** - A classical way of saying someone is sixteen years old ($2 \times 8 = 16$), though sometimes interpreted as eighteen in modern usage
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Author's Notes: This chapter shows the growing tension and chemistry between Ning Fuyi and Chu Qingqiu, as well as setting up the dangerous situation where Chu Qingqiu must infiltrate the mysterious woman's room to gather information about the missing girl.